Build a Care Information File for Mom While There's Time

Four prompts to gather the care information scattered around the house, record where each instruction came from, separate what's true today from guesses about tomorrow, and set a date to check it again.

Where you are

Mom is managing at home. There's a pill organizer on the counter, a letter from the clinic somewhere, and a sheet from the physiotherapist she saw last spring. Nothing is wrong, and you'd like all of it in one place before anything is.

This guide gives you four ChatGPT prompts to organize what you already know and to see what you don't know yet. It is preparation, not an assessment. Use only information you have permission to share, with names removed. The AI organizes and drafts; it does not diagnose, assess safety, or decide. Bring clinical questions to a clinician, and call emergency services for an emergency.

What you'll have at the end

You can open one file and see what help she gets today, every instruction with its source, what she prefers, and what a care team would need to assess fresh, with a date on it.

A one-page Where Things Stand Today sheet: Help she gets today, Instructions we have and where they came from, Her preferences, What a future care team would need to assess, and when it was last checked.

Before you start

- A walk around the house with your phone, photographing anything that looks like a care instruction.
- The names of the professionals Mom sees.
- Her own view of what help she'd accept. One of these is enough to start.

PROMPT 1

Take stock of what's scattered

WHY THIS MATTERS

Care information collects in odd places: a pharmacy bag, a fridge magnet, a text from your sister. Before you can organize it you need to know what exists and where.

WHAT YOU'LL NEED

A rough list of every piece of care information you can find, and where you found it.

COPY THIS PROMPT

> I'm gathering my mother's care information while she is still well. Here is everything I found and where it was:

> [PASTE YOUR LIST]
>
> Make an inventory table with these columns: WHAT IT IS, WHERE IT LIVES NOW, WHO IT CAME FROM, DATE, and STILL CURRENT? For the last two columns, write UNKNOWN wherever I haven't told you, rather than estimating. Then give me a short list of the kinds of care information people often have that I haven't mentioned, such as allergy lists, equipment paperwork, or appointment letters, so I can check whether they exist.

WHAT TO LOOK FOR

How many UNKNOWNs you have in the date and source columns.

WHAT TO DO NEXT

Put everything in one folder, paper or digital, and tell one other family member where it is.

PROMPT 2

Record each instruction with its source

WHY THIS MATTERS

An instruction without a source can't be checked and can't be updated. Two years from now, nobody will remember whether the heel cream was the doctor's idea or a neighbor's.

WHAT YOU'LL NEED

The instructions themselves, copied exactly, and whatever you know about who gave them.

COPY THIS PROMPT

> Here are the care instructions I've found for my mother, copied exactly as written, with whatever I know about where each came from:
>
> [PASTE INSTRUCTIONS]
>
> Put them into a table with three columns: INSTRUCTION AS WRITTEN, WHO GAVE IT AND WHEN, and HOW WE'D CONFIRM IT'S STILL CURRENT. In the first column, copy my wording exactly. Do not rephrase, combine, or add to any medication, dosage, diet, or therapy instruction, and do not comment on whether it seems right. In the third column, only suggest who to ask, such as the prescribing doctor or the pharmacy, not what the answer should be.

WHAT TO LOOK FOR

Instructions you've been following for years that no one has confirmed since.

WHAT TO DO NEXT

At her next routine appointment, ask whether the instructions you have are still the current ones.

PROMPT 3

Keep today apart from tomorrow

WHY THIS MATTERS

When a family has time, the temptation is to plan: she'll need help bathing, she'll need a rail, she'll need someone at night. Those may be true one day. Right now they're guesses, and a guess written into a file starts to look like a decision.

WHAT YOU'LL NEED

Your notes on what help Mom gets today and what you suspect she'll need later.

COPY THIS PROMPT

> Here are my notes about the help my mother gets now and the things I think she might need in the future:
>
> [PASTE YOUR NOTES]
>
> Sort every line into one of three groups. HELP SHE GETS TODAY: things someone actually does for her now, with who does it. WHAT SHE HAS TOLD US SHE WANTS: her own stated preferences. GUESSES ABOUT THE FUTURE: anything that hasn't happened yet. For the third group, rewrite each item as a question a care professional would need to assess, for example “Would she need help with bathing, and what kind?” instead of “She will need help bathing.” Leave those questions open.

WHAT TO LOOK FOR

How much of what you'd written as plan was really prediction.

WHAT TO DO NEXT

Ask Mom which items in the second group she'd want a future carer to know first.

PROMPT 4

Write the Where Things Stand Today page

WHY THIS MATTERS

The point of the file is that someone could pick it up in two years, or in an emergency, and know what's current, what's hers, and what nobody has decided. One page does that better than a folder.

WHAT YOU'LL NEED

The results of the first three prompts.

COPY THIS PROMPT

> This is what I've organized about my mother's current care information:
>
> [PASTE THE RESULTS OF PROMPTS 1 TO 3]
>
> Write a one-page sheet titled WHERE THINGS STAND TODAY with these headings: HELP SHE GETS TODAY; INSTRUCTIONS WE HAVE AND WHERE THEY CAME FROM; HER PREFERENCES; WHAT A FUTURE CARE TEAM WOULD NEED TO ASSESS; and LAST CHECKED. Under the last heading put today's date, my name, and a line reading “Check again by” with a blank for me to fill. Leave the assessment section as questions only. Do not propose any care, treatment, or medication changes, and do not fill any gap I haven't given you information for.

WHAT TO LOOK FOR

A page you'd be comfortable handing to a stranger at a hospital at 2 a.m.

WHAT TO DO NEXT

Write the check-again date on your calendar. A hospital visit, a new prescription, or a fall means check sooner.

Give the file a backbone

A tidy file is a good start. The care interview asks about Mom's whole situation, area by area, and produces a Family Care Profile that gives the information you've gathered a structure a professional can work from.

Create Your Free Family Care Profile ›